## The Singur Singe

By July 2008 the crisis worsened and the workers involved in the Nano project feared for their lives. A month later, Banerjee began an indefinite dharna (strike) in Singur outside the car plant. She was adamant that 400 acres of land be returned to the original owners. She made the point that the landowners of the area had not taken any compensation and that the Tatas required only 600–650 acres of land.

Banerjee asserted that she had no animosity towards the Tata Group and had, in the past, welcomed all industries. But she declared that the people in Singur had been 'cheated … by the ruling government' and as their rights had not been 'recognized or respected', she would fight for them and their cause. In an effort to resolve the crisis, Bhattacharjee invited Banerjee for another round of talks. But it failed.

The situation continued to worsen. In August 2008, the agitation turned violent and the employees working in the premises were forced to stay within its confines till the police arrived. The safety of the workers was at stake. Wagh informed Kant and Ratan about the physical threats to the employees. The chairman was at his wits' end. He suspended the operations at the plant and openly declared his intention of pulling out of the state, despite the sunken costs, if the chief minister could not find a solution.

As the situation appeared to be getting out of hand, in early September, the governor of West Bengal, Gopalkrishna Gandhi, made an attempt to mediate. Both Ratan and Banerjee held discussions, but the talks broke down within a week. Ratan was unhappy with the manner in which the governor mediated the crisis. He felt that Gandhi was not being neutral. He aired his fears in an e-mail to J.J. Irani, lamenting that the governor initiated a 'mediation' process which, in his view, 'was tilted in favour of the lady even before it started'.

Ratan soon found that the project was slipping from his grip. Perhaps for the first time in his career, he could not diffuse a situation. He had handled a crisis like the ULFA militancy but was hopelessly out of his depth in this politically volatile state. As a last-ditch effort, he offered to purchase 400 acres of land across the road from the Nano plot and gift it to the concerned farmers. But Banerjee was adamant. She insisted that the same land that was acquired be returned. It was a game of one-upmanship. Ratan was ready to throw in the towel and leave the state.